

FIELD ARTILLERY AND NAVAL CANNON

Artillery was established as an effective battlefield weapon by the early 16th century, leading to the appearance of a wide range of ordnance, including practical field artillery and lighter pieces for naval use. Improvements in gun-casting technology led to the replacement of wrought-iron guns with stronger bronze cannon, while the introduction of superior corned gunpowder in the late 16th century allowed the construction of longer-range guns with short barrels. By the time of the Thirty Years' War (1618–48) and English Civil War (1642–51), artillery was firmly established, with gun units integrated into infantry regiments.

▲ BRONZE FALCON
Date c.1520
Origin Flanders or France
Length 2.54m (8¼ft)
Calibre 6.3cm
Shot c.1.3kg (2¾lb)

The falcon was a light cannon typical of the early 16th century. This model was ordered by Henry VIII, possibly from Flanders, as England did not have an established gun-manufacturing industry at the time.

Octagonal-shaped barrel

▲ BRONZE SAKER
Date 1529
Origin England
Length 2.23m (7¼ft)
Calibre 9.5cm
Range 2km (1½ miles)

Like many early guns, the saker was named after a bird of prey – in this case, the saker falcon. This one was acquired from an Italian master craftsman as part of Henry VIII's campaign to enlarge his army's artillery force.

Tudor rose symbol

Winged mermaid (facing outwards)

Figure of wyvern (mythical dragon-like creature)

▲ BRONZE ROBINET
Date 1535
Origin France
Length 2.39m (7¾ft)
Calibre 4.3cm
Shot 0.45kg (1lb)

Weighing 193kg (425½lb), this is an extremely ornate example of the robinet, a light cannon. This model was made in Metz, France. It was seized in Paris by Allied troops in 1815.

Elaborately decorated barrel

Small-bore barrel

▲ BRONZE MINION
Date c.1550
Origin Italy
Length 2.5m (8¼ft)
Calibre 7.6cm
Shot 1.5kg (3¼lb)

Minions, light cannon that were particularly well adapted for use at sea, saw service on many English ships during their engagement with the Spanish Armada (see pp.148–49).

▼ IRON BREECH-LOADING SWIVEL GUN
Date 16th century
Origin Europe
Length 1.63m (5¼ft)
Calibre 7.6cm
Shot 1.5kg (3½lb) or grape shot

Pivots that allowed a gun to fire across a wide arc turned a fixed barrel into a swivel gun, especially useful aboard a ship when firing on other moving vessels. This model was used in an antipersonnel role, shooting stone ammunition.

Lever for pivot

Wrought-iron band around barrel